

THE FEDERAL CONTRACTING MASTER GLOSSARY

Every Term, Acronym & Concept You Need to Command the Room

Bradford Starke, Inc. ®

BLUF — BOTTOM LINE UP FRONT

Mastering this vocabulary isn't academic — it's your entry fee to a \$700 billion annual market.

Every word in this glossary represents a rule, a process, or a compliance obligation that separates contractors who win from contractors who wonder why they lost.

CORE REGULATORY FRAMEWORKS

The Master Rulebooks That Govern Every Deal

ACRONYM	FULL TERM	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS (AND WHY IT MATTERS)
FAR	Federal Acquisition Regulation	The primary rulebook governing ALL federal procurement. Think of it as the Constitution of government contracting. Every clause, every contract, every negotiation traces back here. Published jointly by DoD, GSA, and NASA — it has the force of law.
DFARS	Defense Federal Acquisition Regulation Supplement	The Pentagon's expansion pack to the FAR. If you're selling to the Army, Navy, Air Force, or any DoD agency, DFARS clauses will appear in your contract — and they carry heavy cybersecurity, IP, and manufacturing requirements.

ACRONYM	FULL TERM	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS (AND WHY IT MATTERS)
AFARS / GSAM / HHSAR / etc.	Agency FAR Supplements	Every major federal agency publishes its own FAR supplement. The Army has AFARS. GSA has GSAM. HHS has HHSAR. Know your customer's supplement the same way you'd know a client's internal policies before a big pitch.
OFPP	Office of Federal Procurement Policy	The White House's procurement policy arm. OFPP sets the strategic direction for how the entire federal government buys things. Policy memos from OFPP can reshape the market overnight.
FASA	Federal Acquisition Streamlining Act	Landmark 1994 legislation that simplified federal buying. It raised the simplified acquisition threshold, promoted commercial item purchasing, and reduced red tape. Understanding its legacy explains why many modern contract vehicles exist.
FARA	Federal Acquisition Reform Act	A 1996 follow-on reform that further pushed agencies toward commercial buying practices and performance-based contracting. Pair this with FASA to understand the DNA of modern federal acquisition.

CONTRACT VEHICLES & AWARD TYPES

The Delivery Mechanisms for Every Federal Dollar

ACRONYM	FULL TERM	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS (AND WHY IT MATTERS)
IDIQ	Indefinite Delivery / Indefinite Quantity	A master contract with no fixed quantity or delivery schedule. The government commits to a minimum purchase; the contractor is eligible for task orders over the contract's life. IDIQs are the backbone of modern federal contracting — winning one is like securing a preferred vendor status.
GWAC	Governmentwide Acquisition Contract	A special category of IDIQ available to ALL federal agencies, not just the issuing one. GWACs like CIO-SP4 and Alliant 2 are billion-dollar gateways. Getting on one opens the entire federal marketplace.
MAS	Multiple Award Schedule	GSA's massive pre-negotiated catalog of commercial products and services. Formerly called the Federal Supply Schedule (FSS). Being a MAS contractor means agencies can buy from you without running a full competition — it's the federal equivalent of being on an approved vendor list.
BPA	Blanket Purchase Agreement	A streamlined ordering arrangement established against a MAS contract or open market. Think of it as a corporate credit account — the agency sets it up with you once, then places call orders quickly without re-competing. Reduces administrative burden for repeat purchases.
BOA	Basic Ordering Agreement	Similar to a BPA but used for supplies and services where specific quantities aren't known in advance. A BOA is not a contract by itself — actual contracts are formed when orders are placed against it. Common in construction and engineering services.
TOC	Task Order Contract	A contract under which specific scopes of work are assigned via individual task orders. Each task order is its own mini-competition or directed award within the master contract's boundaries. Your revenue lives in the task orders, not the base vehicle.
DOC	Delivery Order Contract	Like a task order contract, but for supplies rather than services. Orders specify quantity, price, and delivery date. Common in commodity procurement.
CPFF	Cost-Plus-Fixed-Fee	A cost-reimbursement contract where the government pays all allowable costs PLUS a fixed fee negotiated upfront. Lower risk for contractors, but

ACRONYM	FULL TERM	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS (AND WHY IT MATTERS)
		requires meticulous cost accounting. The government accepts the financial risk of cost overruns.
CPAF	Cost-Plus-Award-Fee	A cost-reimbursement structure where the contractor earns a base fee plus an award fee determined by a government evaluation board. Your performance score directly dictates your profit margin. Strong incentive to exceed expectations.
CPIF	Cost-Plus-Incentive-Fee	Contractor shares cost savings or overruns with the government per a pre-negotiated formula. Aligns contractor and government financial interests better than CPFF. Typical in complex R&D and large systems development.
FFP	Firm-Fixed-Price	The simplest and most profitable contract type — if you can execute efficiently. Price is set at award and doesn't change. You keep every dollar of cost savings. Risk is entirely on the contractor. Preferred by the government for well-defined requirements.
FPIF	Fixed-Price-Incentive-Firm	A fixed-price contract with a built-in incentive mechanism. Contractor and government share cost savings or overruns up to a ceiling price. Bridges the gap between FFP discipline and CPIF flexibility.
T&M	Time and Materials	The government pays a fixed hourly rate for labor plus actual material costs. Simple to execute but requires government oversight because there's no incentive for efficiency. Contracting officers must certify T&M use is the only practical option.
OTA	Other Transaction Authority	A contracting mechanism OUTSIDE the FAR, used primarily by DoD and DHS to accelerate prototype and follow-on production for innovative technologies. OTAs move at commercial speed. They're not subject to traditional procurement rules — the closest thing to a startup-friendly federal contract.

ACQUISITION PROCESS & COMPETITION

The Game Clock from Idea to Award

ACRONYM	FULL TERM	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS (AND WHY IT MATTERS)
AP	Acquisition Planning	The strategic phase where agencies map out HOW they will buy something before they start buying. A solid AP document sets the timeline, competition strategy, contract type, and evaluation approach. Contractors who understand an agency's acquisition plan before it's published win more.
MR	Market Research	The government's version of competitive intelligence. Agencies must conduct market research before every acquisition to understand what's commercially available, who the capable vendors are, and what pricing looks like. Requests for Information (RFIs) are the primary tool.
RFI	Request for Information	A formal market research tool. The government asks industry for information — capabilities, pricing, timelines — but makes NO commitment to award. Responding to RFIs is how smart contractors shape requirements before a solicitation drops. This is your earliest competitive play.
SSN	Sources Sought Notice	An RFI specifically designed to identify potential small business sources. Agencies use SSNs to determine whether a procurement should be set aside for small businesses. Responding positions you as a known capability in the market.

ACRONYM	FULL TERM	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS (AND WHY IT MATTERS)
RFP	Request for Proposal	The formal solicitation that triggers full competition. The RFP contains the Statement of Work, evaluation criteria, contract terms, and proposal instructions. Everything you write in response will be held against you. READ IT COMPLETELY before writing a single word.
RFQ	Request for Quotation	A simplified solicitation used for smaller purchases, typically under the simplified acquisition threshold or against a MAS contract. Less formal than an RFP. Responses are quotations, not offers — the legal distinction matters.
IFB	Invitation for Bid	Used exclusively for sealed bidding — the most rigid competition method. Lowest price wins, period. No negotiations allowed. Used when requirements are crystal clear and price is the only meaningful differentiator.
SB	Sealed Bidding	A competition method where all bids are submitted by a deadline, opened publicly, and the lowest responsive, responsible bidder wins. No back-and-forth. No negotiation. Price discipline is everything.
NP	Negotiated Procurement	The most common federal acquisition method for services. Allows discussions, clarifications, and final proposal revisions. Best value to the government — not just lowest price — determines the winner.
FOC	Full and Open Competition	The default requirement for federal procurement. Every responsible source must be permitted to compete. Exceptions exist but must be formally justified. Think of it as the government's antitrust law for procurement.
SSA	Sole Source Acquisition	A non-competitive award to a single contractor, justified by one of six statutory exceptions in FAR 6.302. Unique technology, emergency, or national security needs typically qualify. Sole source justifications are public documents — study them to understand your competitive position.
J&A	Justification and Approval	The formal document an agency must complete when deviating from full and open competition. A J&A for a sole source award is a public record — it tells you exactly why a competitor locked out the market and how to challenge it next time.
AS	Acquisition Strategy	The agency's master game plan for a major acquisition. Covers competition approach, contract type selection, risk management, and small business utilization goals. Getting access to an agency's acquisition strategy before an RFP drops is the ultimate competitive advantage.
PAS	Pre-Award Survey	A detailed government assessment of a prospective contractor's technical capability, financial health, quality systems, and past performance BEFORE contract award. Failing one means no award, regardless of your proposal score.

PRICING, COST ACCOUNTING & FINANCE

Where Profit Is Made or Lost

ACRONYM	FULL TERM	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS (AND WHY IT MATTERS)
TINA	Truth in Negotiations Act	Federal law requiring contractors to submit certified cost or pricing data on negotiations above a threshold (currently \$2M). Submitting data you know is inaccurate is a federal crime. The concept is brutal: the government can demand a price reduction after award if they discover you withheld data.

ACRONYM	FULL TERM	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS (AND WHY IT MATTERS)
CPD	Cost or Pricing Data	The factual information contractors must disclose to support a price negotiation. Includes vendor quotes, production costs, labor rates, and overhead rates. Must be current, accurate, and complete as of the date of agreement on price.
DP	Defective Pricing	When a contractor's certified cost data is found to be inaccurate, incomplete, or non-current, the government can reduce the contract price by the overstated amount PLUS interest. A post-award audit nightmare. Get your pricing data right upfront.
CAS	Cost Accounting Standards	Nineteen standards that govern how large government contractors must account for and allocate costs. CAS-covered contracts require consistency in cost accounting practices. Violations trigger the dreaded 'cost impact' analysis — essentially a government demand for money back.
CASB	Cost Accounting Standards Board	The independent board that writes and administers the 19 CAS standards. If you're a large contractor crossing the CAS coverage threshold, CASB rules become your financial operating system.
DS-1 / DS-2	Disclosure Statement	A formal document large contractors must submit describing their cost accounting practices. DS-1 is for educational institutions; DS-2 is for commercial contractors. Any changes to practices require government notification and approval.
FPRA	Forward Pricing Rate Agreement	A pre-negotiated agreement between a contractor and the government on overhead, G&A, and fringe rates for use in future proposals. Having an FPRA speeds up negotiations dramatically — you're not re-litigating rates on every single deal.
FPRR	Forward Pricing Rate Recommendation	When the government can't agree on an FPRA, auditors issue an FPRR — their unilateral recommended rates. Contracting officers use these when negotiating your proposals. Know what your FPRR says.
G&A	General and Administrative Expense	The overhead costs that benefit the company as a whole — executive salaries, legal fees, accounting, and corporate IT. G&A is expressed as a rate and loaded onto direct costs. A high G&A rate makes you less competitive. Control it.
OH	Overhead Rate	Indirect costs associated with a specific business segment — facilities, department management, shared equipment. Pools of overhead costs are allocated to contracts via a base (usually direct labor dollars or hours). Understanding your overhead structure is fundamental to competitive pricing.
FB	Fringe Benefit Rate	The percentage loaded on direct labor to cover employee benefits — health insurance, retirement, payroll taxes, and paid leave. A typical fringe rate ranges from 25–40%. It's not negotiable with employees; it IS a competitive factor in labor pricing.
DCAA	Defense Contract Audit Agency	The government's financial watchdog for DoD contracts. DCAA audits contractor proposals, billing systems, and cost accounting practices. A 'DCAA-approved accounting system' is a prerequisite for cost-type DoD contracts. Getting on their bad side is extraordinarily expensive.
DCMA	Defense Contract Management Agency	The DoD's contract administration arm. DCMA monitors contractor performance, verifies deliveries, and administers contract modifications on DoD contracts. They're embedded at major contractor facilities. Think of them as your permanent on-site government liaison.
AC	Allowable Cost	A cost the government will agree to reimburse under a cost-reimbursement contract. FAR Part 31 defines what's allowable. Lobbying, entertainment, and certain legal fees are examples of UNallowable costs. Charging unallowable costs to the government is fraud.

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IGCE	Independent Government Cost Estimate	The government's internal estimate of what a contract should cost. The IGCE is usually confidential but shapes the evaluation. Your proposal price will be compared against it — being too far above or below raises red flags.
SCA	Should-Cost Analysis	A rigorous government analysis of what a contract SHOULD cost based on efficient contractor performance. Should-cost is more aggressive than an IGCE — it identifies contractor inefficiencies and uses them to drive down your price. Expect it on major acquisitions.

SMALL BUSINESS PROGRAMS

The Government's Affirmative Action for the Private Sector

ACRONYM	FULL TERM	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS (AND WHY IT MATTERS)
SBA	Small Business Administration	The federal agency that defines small business size standards, certifies socioeconomic programs, and advocates for small business interests across the government. The SBA's size standards — based on revenue or employee count — determine whether you qualify for set-asides.
SBSA	Small Business Set-Aside	A procurement reserved exclusively for small business competition. If market research shows two or more capable small businesses exist, the contracting officer MUST set the acquisition aside. Set-asides are the single largest competitive advantage in the market for qualifying firms.
SDVOSB	Service-Disabled Veteran-Owned Small Business	A socioeconomic certification for businesses majority-owned and controlled by veterans with service-connected disabilities. SDVOSBs have access to exclusive set-aside opportunities, particularly at VA. Verification is done through SBA's VetCert program.
VOSB	Veteran-Owned Small Business	Like SDVOSB, but for veterans without a service-connected disability rating. VA gives preference to SDVOSBs first, then VOSBs. Both programs are powerful at VA and increasingly recognized government-wide.
WOSB	Women-Owned Small Business	Businesses at least 51% owned and controlled by women. WOSB set-asides are available in specific NAICS codes where women-owned firms are underrepresented. The Economically Disadvantaged WOSB (EDWOSB) tier adds additional preference for firms meeting income thresholds.
HUBZone	Historically Underutilized Business Zone	Businesses certified by SBA as located in designated economically distressed areas with a workforce majority residing in the zone. HUBZone firms get a 10% price evaluation preference in full and open competitions AND access to set-aside contracts. Location IS a competitive advantage.
8(a)	8(a) Business Development Program	SBA's premier small business development program for socially and economically disadvantaged entrepreneurs. 8(a) firms can receive sole-source awards up to \$4.5M (services) or \$7M (manufacturing) without competition. The 9-year program is one of the most powerful market entry tools in federal contracting.
MPP	Mentor-Protégé Program	A formal teaming structure where a large 'mentor' firm provides business development assistance to a small 'protégé' firm in exchange for joint venture eligibility. SBA and DoD both run versions. A strategic way for large companies to access small business set-asides.
JV	Joint Venture	A formal business entity formed by two or more companies to pursue a specific contract or set of contracts. In small business programs, JVs

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		allow small firms to access large contract vehicles and mentor firms to access set-aside awards. The structure must comply with SBA's affiliation rules.
SBIR	Small Business Innovation Research	A three-phase program that provides R&D funding to innovative small businesses. Phase I is feasibility; Phase II is prototype development; Phase III is commercialization. SBIR is America's largest innovation funding program — and a foot in the door to major defense programs.
STTR	Small Business Technology Transfer	Like SBIR, but requires formal collaboration with a research institution. At least 30% of work must go to the partnering university or federal lab. STTR is the bridge between academic research and commercial application.
SP	Subcontracting Plan	A large contractor's formal commitment to use small businesses as subcontractors. Required on contracts over \$750K (construction: \$1.5M) awarded to large businesses. Goals are set by socioeconomic category. Failing to meet subcontracting goals can cost you future awards.
NAICS	North American Industry Classification System	The six-digit code that defines your industry. The contracting officer assigns a NAICS code to every solicitation, which determines the applicable size standard. Getting classified under the right NAICS code is a foundational competitive decision.

PROPOSAL & EVALUATION PROCESS

The Art of Winning on Paper

ACRONYM	FULL TERM	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS (AND WHY IT MATTERS)
SOW	Statement of Work	The core document defining WHAT the contractor must do. Scope, tasks, deliverables, timelines — it's all here. Your proposal must directly address every SOW requirement. A poorly written SOW is an opportunity; a well-written one is a tight specification.
PWS	Performance Work Statement	Like a SOW, but outcome-focused instead of task-focused. The government tells you WHAT to achieve, not HOW to do it. PWS gives contractors more flexibility — and more risk. It's the preferred format for performance-based acquisitions.
SOO	Statement of Objectives	The broadest requirement document — just high-level goals. The contractor proposes the SOW or PWS as part of the solution. Maximum flexibility. Maximum responsibility. Ideal for innovative solutions where the government doesn't want to over-prescribe.
L&M	Section L and Section M	The most important sections of any RFP. Section L tells you HOW to write your proposal (instructions, format, page limits). Section M tells you HOW you'll be evaluated (criteria, weights). Alignment between your response and Section M criteria is the entire game.
BVT	Best Value Tradeoff	The most common evaluation methodology. The government weighs technical merit, past performance, and price against each other — not just price. A technically superior proposal can win even at a higher price if the evaluators justify the tradeoff.
LPTA	Lowest Price Technically Acceptable	A binary evaluation: meet the technical threshold, then compete purely on price. LPTA commoditizes your capabilities. If you win on quality but not price, you lose. Many industry groups argue LPTA drives down contractor investment in excellence.
SSA	Source Selection	The senior government official with final decision-making power in a

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	Authority	competitive source selection. The SSA reviews the Source Selection Advisory Council's (SSAC) recommendation and makes the award decision. In major acquisitions, this is a general officer or senior executive.
SSEB	Source Selection Evaluation Board	The technical experts who actually read, score, and document evaluations of each proposal against Section M criteria. Their written evaluation record becomes the foundation for any protest. Never give evaluators a reason to write a weakness.
SSAC	Source Selection Advisory Council	Senior officials who review the SSEB's findings and make a recommendation to the SSA. They apply business judgment on top of technical scoring. A proposal that scores well but has a business concern can get flagged here.
CR/AR	Color / Adjectival Rating	Proposal quality ratings used in government evaluations. Typical scale: Outstanding / Blue, Good / Purple, Acceptable / Green, Marginal / Yellow, Unacceptable / Red. One 'Red' rating in a critical area can eliminate an otherwise excellent proposal.
CR	Competitive Range	After initial evaluation, the contracting officer determines which offerors have a reasonable chance of award. Only firms in the competitive range receive discussions. Being cut from the competitive range before discussions is an early death — your proposal must clear this first hurdle.
EWI	Exchanges with Industry	Pre-solicitation communications between government and industry, including one-on-ones, industry days, and draft RFP reviews. FAR encourages these exchanges. They're your best opportunity to shape requirements before the competition formally starts.
OP	Oral Presentations	A live evaluation component where contractors present their solution in person. Increasingly common on major acquisitions. Your key personnel must be present and credible. The evaluators are assessing your team as much as your slides.
PPQ	Past Performance Questionnaire	A survey sent by agencies to references on your prior contracts. References rate your quality, schedule, cost control, management, and small business utilization. A single bad PPQ response in a competitive source selection can cost you millions.
CPARS	Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System	The government's centralized database of contractor performance ratings. Every significant contract gets a CPARS rating. Agencies WILL check your CPARS record before award. Exceptional ratings are a marketable asset; poor ratings follow you for years.

CONTRACT ADMINISTRATION & OVERSIGHT

Life After Award — Where Revenue Is Protected

ACRONYM	FULL TERM	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS (AND WHY IT MATTERS)
CO	Contracting Officer	The only government official with legal authority to sign, modify, or terminate a contract. Never take direction from anyone else — unless they have a CO warrant. Unauthorized commitments made by other government officials are a contractor's nightmare.
COR	Contracting Officer's Representative	The government's on-the-ground technical manager for your contract. The COR monitors performance, approves deliverables, and communicates with the contractor daily — but cannot change the contract without the CO's authority. Build this relationship carefully.

ACRONYM	FULL TERM	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS (AND WHY IT MATTERS)
PM	Program Manager	The government's overall program champion. The PM controls requirements, budget, and schedule at the program level. The CO executes the PM's acquisition strategy. Knowing both — and who has more influence — is essential for long-term relationship management.
Mod	Contract Modification	Any change to a signed contract. Mods can be bilateral (both parties sign) or unilateral (government only). Every scope change, period of performance extension, or price adjustment comes through a mod. NEVER perform work without a signed mod for it.
Uni-Mod	Unilateral Modification	A contract change issued by the government alone, without contractor agreement. Administrative changes and no-cost modifications are typical. If a CO issues a unilateral mod that changes your costs or obligations, you may be entitled to a Request for Equitable Adjustment.
REA	Request for Equitable Adjustment	A formal contractor request for additional compensation or time due to government-caused changes or delays. REAs are not disputes — they're requests. Document every government-caused impact in real time. Waiting until contract end to reconstruct costs is a losing strategy.
COFD	Contracting Officer's Final Decision	The government's official written decision on a contractor claim. Once issued, the clock starts on your right to appeal. You have 90 days to go to the Armed Services Board of Contract Appeals (ASBCA) or 12 months to sue in the Court of Federal Claims.
CN	Cure Notice	A formal warning that the contractor is failing to meet contract requirements, giving you a specific number of days to 'cure' the problem. Ignore it and you face termination for default. Respond to it aggressively — in writing — with a recovery plan.
SCN	Show Cause Notice	More serious than a cure notice. A SCN demands the contractor explain why the contract should NOT be terminated for default. Your written response is a legal document. Get legal counsel involved immediately.
T4C	Termination for Convenience	The government's unilateral right to end a contract at any time for any reason — even if you've done nothing wrong. You're entitled to recover costs incurred plus a reasonable profit on work performed. Understand settlement procedures; they're not automatic.
T4D	Termination for Default	Termination because the contractor failed to perform. The government can demand repurchase costs from the defaulted contractor. A T4D on your record is devastating to future business — and it's often litigated back to T4C on appeal.
LD	Liquidated Damages	Pre-negotiated penalties per day of schedule delay, written into the contract upfront. LDs substitute for actual damages — the government doesn't need to prove what a delay cost them. Missing a delivery date with LD clauses in your contract is an immediate financial hit.
VE	Value Engineering	A program where contractors propose cost-saving changes to the contract. If the government accepts, the contractor typically shares in the savings. VE is one of the few ways to generate upside on a fixed-price contract after award.
EVM	Earned Value Management	A rigorous project management methodology that integrates technical scope, schedule, and cost into a single performance measurement system. Required on major acquisition programs over \$50M. The Earned Value Management System (EVMS) is a major compliance undertaking — and a major competitive differentiator.

COMPLIANCE, ETHICS & SECURITY

The Rules That Cannot Be Broken

ACRONYM	FULL TERM	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS (AND WHY IT MATTERS)
FASCSA	Federal Acquisition Supply Chain Security Act	Landmark legislation authorizing government-wide exclusion orders against supply chain threats. In the current geopolitical environment, supply chain provenance is no longer just a quality issue — it's a national security requirement that can disqualify non-compliant contractors.
CMMC	Cybersecurity Maturity Model Certification	DoD's mandatory cybersecurity certification framework for contractors handling controlled information. Three tiers of certification (Foundational, Advanced, Expert) are assessed by third-party organizations. By 2026, no CMMC certification means no DoD contract. It is that simple.
CUI	Controlled Unclassified Information	Government information that requires protection but isn't classified. Handling CUI requires compliance with NIST SP 800-171 standards. If DoD data touches your networks, CUI compliance is non-negotiable — and CMMC certifies you're living up to it.
NISP	National Industrial Security Program	The framework governing how cleared defense contractors handle classified information. If you want to work on classified programs, you need a Facility Clearance (FCL) under NISP. The Defense Counterintelligence and Security Agency (DCSA) administers the program.
FCL	Facility Clearance	An administrative determination that a contractor facility is eligible to access classified information. FCLs are tied to physical facilities and key management personnel. They can take 6–18 months to obtain. Plan your entry into classified work accordingly.
SAM	System for Award Management	The government's single registration database for all federal contractors. You CANNOT receive a federal contract or grant without an active SAM.gov registration. Maintain it annually — a lapsed registration can prevent award even after you win.
EPLS	Excluded Parties List System	Now integrated into SAM.gov. Lists contractors and individuals suspended or debarred from federal contracting. Contracting officers must verify no party on a contract is excluded. Appearing on this list is effectively a market death sentence.
D&S	Debarment and Suspension	Administrative actions that exclude a contractor from federal awards for a defined period. Suspension is temporary (pending investigation); debarment can last up to three years. Both are devastating. The cause is almost always fraud, ethics violations, or criminal conduct.
OCI	Organizational Conflict of Interest	A situation where a contractor's objectivity is impaired or they have an unfair competitive advantage due to prior work. OCIs can disqualify you from competing — or get your award overturned on protest. Disclose potential OCIs proactively; never hide them.
FCA	False Claims Act	The federal government's most powerful anti-fraud tool. Prohibits knowingly submitting false claims for payment. Penalties include treble damages plus per-claim fines. The qui tam provision allows whistleblowers to sue on the government's behalf and collect a percentage of recovery.
AKA	Anti-Kickback Act	Federal law prohibiting kickbacks in government subcontracting — meaning any payment, gift, or favor to influence a subcontract award. FAR subcontracting clauses flow this requirement down. Violations are criminal and civil, not just contractual.
IG	Inspector General	The watchdog office within each federal agency responsible for detecting fraud, waste, and abuse. IGs conduct audits, investigations, and program evaluations. A referral to an agency IG is not something to

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		take lightly — cooperate fully and immediately involve counsel.
GAO	Government Accountability Office	Congress's independent watchdog. The GAO conducts bid protests, audits government programs, and issues reports to Congress. A GAO bid protest is the most common way to challenge a contract award — and one of the contractor's most powerful legal tools.
BAA	Buy American Act	Requires federal agencies to purchase domestic end products for supplies delivered inside the U.S. Percentage of domestic content defines compliance. The requirements have tightened significantly under recent executive orders. Verify your supply chain's country of origin.
TAA	Trade Agreements Act	Applies to MAS contracts and certain other procurements. Requires that products be manufactured in the U.S. or a 'designated country' — largely U.S. trade partners. Products from China, Russia, and several other countries do NOT qualify. A TAA violation can kill a contract.

KEY AGENCIES & OFFICES

Know Your Customers — and Their Buying Offices

ACRONYM	FULL TERM	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS (AND WHY IT MATTERS)
GSA	General Services Administration	The federal government's central buying and real estate agency. GSA manages the Multiple Award Schedule (MAS) program, GWACs like Alliant 2 and OASIS, and the entire federal real estate portfolio. For commercial products and professional services, GSA is the gateway to the entire civilian market.
DoD	Department of Defense	The federal government's largest customer — spending over \$400B annually on goods and services. DoD is not one customer; it's Army, Navy, Air Force, Marines, Space Force, DLA, DARPA, and dozens of other components, each with their own procurement offices and missions.
DLA	Defense Logistics Agency	The DoD's massive supply chain manager, buying everything from food to fuel to aircraft parts for all military branches. DLA is one of the world's largest buyers of commodity goods. Long-term supply agreements and prime vendor contracts are the path in.
DARPA	Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency	The DoD's innovation engine, responsible for breakthrough technologies that have created the internet, GPS, and stealth aircraft. DARPA uses OTAs, BAAs, and other flexible contracting mechanisms. It's high risk, high potential, and the fastest path from lab to battlefield.
DHS	Department of Homeland Security	A major civilian agency buyer spanning border security, cybersecurity, FEMA, and the Coast Guard. DHS uses strong small business and OTA programs. Cybersecurity — through CISA — is its fastest-growing mission and procurement area.
HHS	Department of Health and Human Services	The largest civilian agency by budget. HHS components include NIH (research funding), CDC (public health), FDA (regulatory), and CMS (Medicare/Medicaid IT). Health IT, grants management, and public health services represent massive contracting opportunities.
NASA	National Aeronautics and Space Administration	A premier research and development buyer with sophisticated acquisition approaches. NASA's co-authorship of the FAR means their supplement (NFS) is deeply integrated. Commercial space is transforming NASA contracting toward partnership models, OTAs, and fixed-price structures.

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OMB	Office of Management and Budget	The White House's management and budget arm. OMB issues government-wide procurement policy memoranda, sets IT investment controls, and manages the federal budget process. OMB's Circular A-123 and IT acquisition policies shape contractor opportunities across government.
SBA	Small Business Administration	More than just a lender — the SBA certifies small business status, runs the 8(a) and HUBZone programs, manages Mentor-Protegé agreements, and advocates for small business participation across all federal agencies. Know your size. Know your programs. Know SBA.

INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY & DATA RIGHTS

Protecting Your Most Valuable Asset

ACRONYM	FULL TERM	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS (AND WHY IT MATTERS)
RTD	Rights in Technical Data	The government's rights to use, modify, reproduce, and disclose contractor-developed technical data and software. Negotiating data rights is a major strategic decision — giving the government broad rights can allow them to re-compete work you consider proprietary.
UR	Unlimited Rights	The government can do anything with your technical data — share it, give it to competitors, publish it. Unlimited rights typically attach to data developed entirely with government funding. Guard against this in negotiations.
LR	Limited Rights	The most protective status for technical data developed entirely at private expense. The government gets only a narrow, defined use. Limited rights data cannot be shared with other contractors without your permission. Asserting limited rights requires proper marking and documentation.
GPR	Government Purpose Rights	A middle-ground data rights status for data developed with mixed funding. The government can use the data for its own purposes and share it with other government agencies, but cannot release it to the public or competitors for five years. After five years, it converts to unlimited rights.
RR	Restricted Rights	The commercial software equivalent of limited rights. Applied to commercial software where the government gets only the right to use the specific copy purchased. The government cannot reverse-engineer, reproduce, or distribute restricted rights software.
SBIR DR	Small Business Innovation Research Data Rights	SBIR recipients have special statutory data rights protection for 20 years from the date of contract award. This protection is a core incentive for small innovative firms to participate in SBIR. Understand it before you sign any SBIR contract or commercialization agreement.

PERFORMANCE & PROGRAM MANAGEMENT

Executing With Discipline — Because Awards Don't Pay Themselves

ACRONYM	FULL TERM	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS (AND WHY IT MATTERS)
PBA	Performance-Based	A contracting approach that defines requirements in terms of

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	Acquisition	measurable outcomes rather than prescriptive tasks. The Performance Work Statement (PWS) and Quality Assurance Surveillance Plan (QASP) are the cornerstone documents. You decide HOW to deliver; the government measures WHAT you delivered.
QASP	Quality Assurance Surveillance Plan	The government's evaluation plan for monitoring contractor performance under a PBA contract. Defines the metrics, surveillance methods, and performance standards the government uses to assess you. Read the QASP before you price a PBA contract — it defines exactly what you'll be held to.
SLA	Service Level Agreement	Specific, measurable performance commitments written into a contract, typically for IT and managed services. SLAs drive incentives and penalties. Missing an SLA in a critical system can trigger financial consequences even on an FFP contract.
IMS	Integrated Master Schedule	A comprehensive, resource-loaded project schedule that ties together all work activities, milestones, and deliverables for a complex program. Required on major DoD acquisitions. The IMS is the contractor's operating plan — and the government's early warning system for schedule risk.
WBS	Work Breakdown Structure	A hierarchical decomposition of all work in a project. The WBS is the foundation of cost estimation, scheduling, and earned value reporting. Government programs often specify a required WBS structure in the SOW — align your proposal to it.
IBR	Integrated Baseline Review	A formal government review of the contractor's performance measurement baseline (PMB) — their plan for executing the contract within the agreed cost and schedule. An IBR typically occurs within the first few months of award. Come prepared: it's an audit of your project management credibility.
TPM	Technical Performance Measure	Key technical parameters tracked throughout a program to assess progress against requirements. Missing a TPM is an early warning sign of future cost or schedule overruns. Proactive TPM management separates excellent program managers from average ones.
SETR	Systems Engineering Technical Review	A series of formal milestone reviews (PDR, CDR, TRR, etc.) in a DoD acquisition program where the design is evaluated against requirements. Contractors must prepare rigorously for SETRs — they are program-defining events with real consequences for award fee and program continuation.

★ **PRO-TIP:** Don't just memorize these terms — learn the FAR part number behind each one. When you can cite FAR 15.305 in a proposal debrief or reference FAR 52.227-14 in a data rights negotiation, you stop being a vendor and start being a trusted advisor.